



THE BITFINEX HEIST

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TRUST LEFT THE EXCHANGE.

On 2 August 2016, Bitfinex announced a security breach and stopped trading, deposits and withdrawals. Bitcoin had been stolen from customer wallets. The exchange went offline while it investigated and secured its systems; other digital tokens were reported unaffected.

About 120,000 BTC had left the exchange. Later court documents described how Ilya Lichtenstein entered Bitfinex's systems and fraudulently authorised more than 2,000 transactions to a wallet he controlled. The failure was in exchange custody and transaction authorisation. Bitcoin's underlying network had not been broken.

The loss became a problem for customers as well as the exchange. Bitfinex issued BFX tokens to compensate for dollar-denominated losses. The company says all BFX holders had redeemed those tokens or exchanged them for iFinex shares within eight months. That response belongs to the aftermath of the breach, not the instant pictured here.

The driver is an anime interpretation of Lichtenstein, whose role as the hacker emerged in the later criminal case. A speedboat carrying digital-value cases turns unauthorised transfers into a visible getaway. The Hong Kong waterfront, branded building and escape are imagined staging, not a documented journey, crime scene or Bitfinex office.

DETAILS IN THE ART

01 THE MAN AT THE HELM

The character is inspired by Ilya Lichtenstein, identified in the later criminal case as the hacker. His pose and speedboat journey are fictional; the actual theft used unauthorised digital transfers.

02 119,755 BTC

The case display uses the amount reported in Bitfinex's recovery FAQ. DOJ documents give 119,754 BTC; the story uses about 120,000 rather than treating those exact figures as identical.

03 WITHDRAWALS HALTED

The red sign echoes the exchange's real suspension of withdrawals, deposits and trading on 2 August. The illuminated facade is an invented visualisation of that announcement, not a verified physical notice.

04 THE BITFINEX CASE

The branded cargo represents bitcoin taken from exchange custody. It is a symbolic digital-value container, not evidence that physical bitcoin cases were transported by boat.

SOURCE & ART NOTE

Sources: Bitfinex's [2 August breach notice](#), its [recovery FAQ](#), and the [DOJ case account](#). City reference: Malcolm Koo, [Victoria Harbour at night](#) (2012), [CC BY 4.0](#), reinterpreted as an illustration. Character, building, boat and cargo are symbolic adaptations; no physical escape or exact office location is claimed. No cross-card cameo is identified.